

Honduras



Still recovering from a devastating hurricane in 1998, while it nurtures a fragile democracy.

1821 After forming part of the Captaincy-General of Guatemala, Honduras becomes independent from Spain and part of Mexico until 1823, and then part of the United Provinces of Central America until 1838.

1838 Declares full independence.

1890s US banana plantations set up.

1932–49 Dictatorship of General Tiburcio Carías Andino of National Party of Honduras (PNH).

1954 Liberal Party of Honduras's (PLH) president-elect Villeda Morales is deposed but reelected in 1957 (serving to 1963).

1963 Military coup.

1969 Six-day Soccer War with El Salvador sparked by a controversial World Cup match.

1980–83 PLH wins elections but General Gustavo Alvarez holds real power. Military maneuvers with US. Trade unionists arrested; death squads operate.

1984 Return to democracy.

1988 Twelve thousand Contra rebels are forced out of Nicaragua into Honduras.

1995 Military defies human rights abuse charges.

1998 Hurricane Mitch wreaks havoc, causing the deaths of at least 5,600 people and damage estimated at \$3 billion.

1999 Appointment of first civilian defense minister, consolidating the transition to civilian rule.

1999 Miskito Amerindians, about 45,000, and the English-speaking *garifuna* (black) population on the Caribbean coast unite to oppose a constitutional amendment allowing foreigners to buy land in coastal areas, traditionally their communal lands.

2006 Manuel Zelaya of the Liberal Party becomes president after a bitterly contested election. He wins on a platform of tackling gang violence and drug trafficking.

2009 Zelaya is deposed by the military and replaced by Roberto Micheletti, the Speaker of Congress. The US rejects the coup and the Organization of American States (OAS) suspends Honduras. Zelaya attempts a return but is not reinstated, so goes into exile in the Dominican Republic. Porfirio Lobo Sosa wins the November elections and becomes president.

«210–13 Pre-Columbian Americas
«214–15 Aztec to Inca
«232–33 The Great Food Exchange

El Salvador



The smallest and most densely populated republic in Central America.

1522 A Spanish expeditionary force disembarks in the Gulf of Fonseca and calls the territory Cuscatlan.

1525 San Salvador is founded by Diego de Alvarado before being transferred to its present location in 1528.

1821 The territory, which forms part of the Captaincy-General of Guatemala, proclaims its independence from Spain as part of the United Provinces of Central America. Years of internal conflict ensue.

1838 The Act of Independence is signed in Guatemala.

1841 El Salvador finally leaves the United Provinces.

1849 El Salvador is confirmed as an independent sovereign republic.

1932 Army crushes popular insurrection led by Farabundo Martí.

1944–79 Army rules through National Conciliation Party (PCN).

1979 Reformist officers overthrow PCN government.

1981 Left-wing Farabundo Martí National Liberation Movement (FMLN) launches civil war.

1989 Right-wing Arena (Nationalist Republican Alliance) party wins the presidential election.

1992 UN-brokered peace between the government and the FMLN, which is now recognized as a political party.

1997 Leftists wins mayoralty of San Salvador and half the state capitals.

1999 Arena's Francisco Flores wins presidential election, reducing the FMLN to a distant second. Flores promises to reduce poverty and redistribute income.

2000 FMLN wins assembly elections, retaining power in 2003.

2001 Devastating earthquakes kill hundreds; dollarization of economy.

2004 Arena retains the presidency, won by Elías Antonio (Tony) Saca, a popular former sports correspondent.

2009 Mauricio Funes of the FMNL wins general election, becoming El Salvador's first left-wing president since the end of the civil war. The FMNL has the most seats in parliament.

«230–31 Contact Americas
«232–33 The Great Food Exchange
«438–39 Dictatorship and Democracy

Nicaragua



A country recovering from years of civil war between the government and US-backed guerrillas.

1544 Nicaragua is incorporated into the Captaincy-General of Guatemala.

1821 Nicaragua becomes independent from Spain and is incorporated into the United Provinces of Central America.

1838 When the United Provinces fall apart, Nicaragua becomes a republic.

1856 US adventurer William Walker proclaims himself president as part of a move to establish a slave republic in Central America.

1905 The Altamirano–Harrison treaty between the UK and Nicaragua recognizes full Nicaraguan sovereignty over the Atlantic coast, where the UK had a protectorate until 1894.

1909 US marines land in Bluefields and bring to power Juan Estrada, who signs pacts placing Nicaragua effectively under US administration. The Marines intervene in Nicaragua again in 1912–25 and in 1926–33.

1936 Anastasio Somoza takes power after the National Guard forces President Sacasa's resignation, instituting a 53-year family dictatorship.

1956 On Somoza's assassination he is succeeded by his son Luis and, in 1967, by his other son Anastasio.

1962 Foundation of the Sandinista National Liberation Front (FSLN).

1974 The FSLN offensive against the Somoza government gathers force, intensifying into civil war by 1978.

1979 President Somoza flees into exile. The Sandinistas take power and redistribute land to landless peasants.

1981 Rebel Contra guerrillas based in Honduras and funded by the US begin military campaign against the Sandinista government.



Hurricane Mitch

A devastating blow to Nicaragua came in October 1998, when Hurricane Mitch wrecked the country, destroying the tourist industry and causing at least 3,800 deaths and many more injuries.

1984 Sandinista leader Daniel Ortega elected president.

1986 Nicaragua wins case at International Court of Justice against US violations of its sovereignty.

1988 Hurricane Mitch wrecks country.

1990 Civil war ends. Multi-party elections result in the surprise defeat of Ortega and the victory of Violeta Chamorro, widow of a Somoza opponent assassinated in 1978, at the head of anti-Sandinista coalition.

1996 Arnaldo Alemán of the Constitutional Liberal Party again defeats Ortega and the Sandinistas, who go on to lose again in 2001.

2006 Daniel Ortega returns to power in presidential election.

«230–31 Contact Americas
«232–33 The Great Food Exchange
«438–39 Dictatorship and Democracy

Costa Rica



Costa Rica is the most stable Central American country, with a highly developed welfare state.

1502 Columbus lands during the course of his last voyage. In the second half of the century the territory is annexed to the Captaincy-General of Guatemala and becomes a European-oriented society of small landowners.

1821–38 Upon independence Costa Rica forms part of the United Provinces of Central America until its dissolution.

1948 Disputed elections lead to civil war; ended by Social Democratic Party (later the National Liberation Party, the PLN) forming a provisional military government under José Figueres Ferrer. The army is then abolished and a highly developed welfare state is introduced.

1949 New constitution is promulgated, forbidding national armies. A civil guard and police force keep order.

1987 Central American Peace Plan initiated by President Óscar Arias of the PLN in an effort to bring peace to the region; he wins the Nobel Peace Prize that year.

2006 Former president Óscar Arias returns to power promising a fresh start after a series of corruption scandals.

2007 Costa Rica votes for ratification of the Central American Free Trade Area (CAFTA).

2010 Laura Chinchilla becomes Costa Rica's first female president.

«230–31 Contact Americas
«232–33 The Great Food Exchange
«438–39 Dictatorship and Democracy